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What Fetu Afahye Reveals About Lagoon Stewardship and Sanitation

Article written by Ms Cindy Owusu & Dr. Alberta Sagoe

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RESEARCH SPOTLIGHT IN BRIEF

WASMaN Spotlights the research of Ms Cindy Owusu, which explores how Cape Coast's Fetu Afahye (festival) brings culture, traditional fisheries stewardship and environmental sanitation together at the Fosu Lagoon. Using photographs and videos recorded before, during and after the festival, the study documents the lagoon clean-up, the “Bakatue” ritual that ends the fishing restriction, the first casting of the net, and the ceremonial catch. The visual evidence shows an immediate reduction in visible surface litter and highlights the community authority behind the temporary fishing closure. It does not, however, prove lasting improvements in water quality or fish biodiversity. The spotlight therefore calls for year-round sanitation, repeated ecological monitoring and respectful collaboration between traditional authorities, researchers, public institutions and lagoon users.

Oguaa Fetu Afahye

The Fosu Lagoon is central to Oguaa cultural traditions, livelihoods and ecological heritage. Every year, as Cape Coast prepares for Oguaa Fetu Afahye in September, the Fosu Lagoon becomes more than the setting for a festival. It becomes a place where culture, community authority, fishing, and environmental care meet.



Figure 1: Fosu Lagoon, Cape Coast – Central Region, Ghana. Photo credit: Kofi Kapo, Tiktok@kofiakapo21, 2026



A temporary restriction on fishing before the festivities is lifted through the Bakatue ritual; the Omanhene casts the first net; and the first catch is received – not simply as fish, but as a sign carrying meaning for the year ahead. At the same time, organized communal cleaning changes the visible condition of the lagoon. Waste is removed, the water surface looks clearer, and public attention turns towards a water body that remains central to the identity of Cape Coast. To promote sustainable lagoon management, it is essential to explore how these traditional practices can be systematically integrated into long-term environmental strategies, ensuring cultural relevance and ecological health.

A festival rooted in cleansing and renewal

Fetu Afahye is celebrated by the chiefs and people of the Oguua Traditional Area, usually culminating on the first Saturday of September. Ghana Tourism Authority's account of the festival traces it to a period when the community was affected by a plague and sought spiritual intervention. The festival came to represent purification, gratitude and renewal. The same account explains that the name Fetu is associated with “clearing the dirt”, giving environmental cleanliness a deep cultural resonance rather than making it a recent addition to the celebration.

Before the festival, restrictions are placed on noise-making and fishing in the Fosu Lagoon. The festival programme also includes Amuntumadeze, or Health Day, when community members clean and improve their surroundings. The Bakatue ritually marks the ceremonial reopening of the lagoon. Following ritual observances, the Omanhene (Paramount Chief) casts a net three times to signify the lifting of the fishing restriction. The catch is interpreted culturally as an indication of the prospects for the coming season. Beyond granting permission to resume fishing, the ceremony also shows who holds authority, how a community rule is announced and how access to an aquatic resource is connected to collective identity and belief.



Figure 2: Ritual performance signifying the lifting of the temporary fishing ban. Photo Credit: Cape Coast Gallery, 2026



Figure 3: Images of the first casting of net and the first catch during Bakatue. Photo credit: Tiktok @Fetu Afahye, 2026

What the visual record captures

During the 2026 Oguaa Fetu Afahye, Cindy documented images of the lagoon before and after cleaning, videos of its surface condition, footage of the Bakatue ritual, photographs showing the lifting of the ban, the first casting of the net, and the first catch.

The before-and-after images provide a clear visual narrative of immediate change. In the areas photographed, cleaning reduced visible surface litter and improved the appearance of the lagoon. The ritual footage recorded the public transition from restriction to renewed access, while the images of the first catch depicted a culturally important moment that is rarely examined through an environmental research lens.





Figure 3: Bakaano, Fosu Lagoon. Matched views of the lagoon before (left) and immediately after (right) the 2026 festival clean-up. Photo credit: BuzStop Boys, 2026.

The evidence is valuable, but its boundaries are equally important. A cleaner-looking surface does not necessarily mean that water quality has improved. Photographs cannot show dissolved pollutants, contamination in sediment, or waste beneath the water. Likewise, one ceremonial catch cannot measure fish population size, species diversity, spawning success, or the ecological effect of the temporary closure. To fully understand the lagoon's ecological health, systematic data collection on water chemistry, sediment quality, fish populations, and habitat conditions over time is necessary. This comprehensive approach will help determine whether visible improvements translate into genuine ecological benefits.

Tradition overlaps with Science

The temporary fishing restriction prior to the festival is mirrored in contemporary fisheries management practice – seasonal closures to reduce fishing pressure for a set period, to protect fish during vulnerable stages and allow aquatic systems to recover. In Fosu Lagoon, however, the closure is rooted in cultural and spiritual practice. Its authority is based on tradition, community observance, and chieftaincy, rather than solely on modern regulation.

This is significant because effective resource management relies not only on technical rules but also on legitimacy, shared meaning, and compliance. Bakatue shows how traditional institutions can publicly communicate restrictions and mark their end through ceremonies understood by the community. It provides a valuable example of indigenous and local knowledge contributing to environmental governance.



The closure should not, however, be presented as proof of biological recovery. Its duration, timing and ecological effect would need to be assessed using repeated data on species, catch, fish size, fishing effort and habitat condition. Pollution may also limit any benefit gained from a temporary pause in fishing. The strongest conclusion at this stage is that the ritual creates a culturally legitimate period of restraint and offers a foundation on which scientific monitoring and collaborative management could be built.



Figure 4: The ceremonial first catch after the temporary fishing ban is lifted. Photo Credit: Cape Coast Gallery, 2026.

The sanitation question

The festival also demonstrates the power of a shared event to mobilise environmental action. Clean-up exercises concentrate labour, public attention and institutional support within a short period. The immediate visual result can be striking, especially when heavily littered areas are cleared. The more difficult question is whether that improvement lasts. Waste entering the lagoon is shaped by everyday systems and behaviour: bin availability, collection schedules, drainage, dumping practices, enforcement, public awareness, and the responsibilities of institutions and businesses. A festival clean-up can remove accumulated waste, but it cannot by itself prevent new waste from entering the lagoon after the celebrations end.

The photographs therefore tell two related stories. The first is hopeful: coordinated community action can quickly improve the visible condition of an aquatic environment. The second is a warning: without year-round services and monitoring, a clean-up may become a temporary reset rather than a lasting solution. Fetu Afahye can be used as a powerful annual platform for environmental education, but the message must be supported by routine action throughout the year.





Figure 5. Community members and waste management partners removing visible waste from the lagoon environment ahead of Fetu Afahye.

A shared responsibility for the Fosu Lagoon

Fetu Afahye reveals an important connection between culture and environmental stewardship. Through Bakatue, the community recognises a period when fishing stops and a public moment when access resumes. Through clean-up activities, residents and partners demonstrate that visible environmental change is possible when people act together.

The next step is to carry that commitment beyond the festival. Traditional authorities, the Cape Coast Metropolitan Assembly, researchers, sanitation providers, businesses, schools, civil society organisations and lagoon users all have roles to play. Priorities include reliable waste collection, controlling dumping, public education, routine monitoring, and involving residents in reporting and solving sanitation problems.



From spotlight to longer-term research

This initial documentation presents a starting point for a stronger community-based monitoring programme. Future photographs should be taken from fixed points before cleaning, immediately afterwards, and again after two weeks, one month and three months. Simple litter counts along defined sections of the shoreline would make comparisons more reliable. With appropriate technical support, basic measurements of dissolved oxygen, turbidity, pH, temperature and conductivity could help determine whether changes in appearance correspond with changes in water condition.

Fish monitoring would require more than the ceremonial catch. Recording species, number, size range, gear and effort across several comparable fishing events would provide a better basis for discussing biodiversity and the possible effects of the closure. Short interviews with traditional leaders, fishers, festival organisers, sanitation officials, traders and lagoon-side residents would also help explain how the restriction is enforced, how cleaning is organised and why waste returns.

Such work should respect the cultural and spiritual significance of the ritual. Permission is needed before publishing identifiable images or sensitive knowledge, and traditional authorities should guide how sacred aspects of the ceremony are represented. A collaborative approach would allow scientific methods to complement, rather than displace, the knowledge and authority already associated with the lagoon.

Sources and further reading

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